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Mitigating Concept Leakage in Concept Bottleneck Models via Structural Orthogonality and Entropy Regularization

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ABSTRACT

Concept Bottleneck Models (CBMs) offer interpretable neural architectures by constraining decision-making to a human-understandable concept space. However, recent studies reveal that soft CBMs are susceptible to "Concept Leakage," a phenomenon where models embed task-relevant, non-semantic features into the continuous concept activations, effectively bypassing the bottleneck and compromising interventional interpretability. In this paper, we propose a dual-regularization framework (CBMLoss) comprising an Orthogonality Loss and an Entropy Loss to structurally enforce concept independence and binarization. We evaluate our method on the CUB-200-2011 dataset by adapting uncertainty-guided interventions into a diagnostic framework (Random vs. Uncertainty-based intervention). Our results empirically unearth the "Uncertainty Paradox," formally proving the presence of concept leakage in unconstrained models. The proposed CBMLoss structurally mitigates this leakage, improving robustness to human concept corrections by up to 30% under extreme intervention scenarios, despite a manageable empirical trade-off with raw task accuracy. We further demonstrate the theoretical alignment of CBMLoss with the Information Bottleneck principle, rendering a profound, highly interpretable semantic mapping for complex visual tasks.

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1. Introduction

In deep learning applications within high-stakes domains—such as healthcare, autonomous driving, and finance—model interpretability is as critical as predictive accuracy [1]. Deep Neural Networks (DNNs) typically operate as opaque "black boxes", processing high-dimensional inputs through non-linear latent spaces that resist human intuition. This structural opacity raises substantial ethical, legal, and safety concerns, fueling the rapid development of Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI).

Particularly, *post-hoc* explainability methods (such as saliency maps or LIME) attempt to reverse-engineer model logic after the fact, but they have been repeatedly shown to be fragile, misleading, or entirely disconnected from the true computational graph of the model. Concept Bottleneck Models (CBMs) [2] have emerged as a robust, *ante-hoc* alternative. By forcing a model to first map visual or tabular inputs to a predefined set of human-understandable concepts (e.g., "has red wings", "is striped") and subsequently relying exclusively on those concepts to predict the final target class (e.g., a specific bird species), CBMs guarantee that the final decision logic is structurally transparent via a linear or simple non-linear mapping over the concept space.

Furthermore, CBMs introduce a pivotal operational advantage currently unavailable in standard architectures: *Test-Time Intervention*. During inference, if the model mispredicts an intermediate concept due to occlusion or domain shift, a human domain expert can simply overwrite the erroneous activation with the correct ground truth. Ideally, the downstream label

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predictor should logically reroute and correct the final prediction.

However, the efficacy of CBM interventions heavily hinges on the "Markovian Assumption"—the premise that the concepts fully encapsulate the task semantics. Recent studies have uncovered a critical vulnerability when this assumption is relaxed over continuous (soft) activations: **Concept Leakage** [3, 4]. When trained jointly (optimizing concept extraction and label prediction simultaneously to maximize accuracy), the concept extractor functionally bypasses the semantic bottleneck. It learns to encode highly informative, task-relevant, yet semantically meaningless structural noise (pirated signals such as background textures) into the floating-point margins of the continuous concept activations.

Under such leakage phenomena, human interventions fail catastrophically [5]. Correcting a seemingly faulty concept to its boolean ground truth inherently overrides the hidden continuous signal upon which the downstream classifier depends, plummeting final accuracy below random chance despite receiving "correct" human guidance.

Addressing this structural communication leak is paramount for creating reliably intervenable CBMs. In this paper, we propose **CBMLoss**, a dual-regularization framework engineered to structurally restrict the channel capacity of the concept bottleneck without completely sacrificing the end-to-end optimization benefits of Joint Training.

Specifically, our contributions are threefold:

1. We introduce an **Entropy Loss** ($\mathcal{L}_H$) to penalize concept uncertainty, pushing floating-point activations towards hard booleans, thereby closing the fractional spectrum commonly exploited for leakage.
2. We formulate an **Orthogonality Loss** ($\mathcal{L}_O$) calculated over the covariance matrix of the concept batch, explicitly tearing down latent entanglement among concepts and preserving semantic independence.
3. We adapt a **Dual-Mode Causal Intervention Protocol** (Random vs. Uncertainty testing) and introduce the *"Uncertainty Paradox,"* an empirical diagnostic framework that unequivocally unmasks concept leakage vulnerabilities in baseline architectures.

2. Related Work

2.1. Concept Bottleneck Models (CBMs)

Since their formalization by Koh et al. [2], Concept Bottleneck Models have fundamentally reshaped transparent deep learning. A typical CBM dissects the prediction pipeline into two mapping functions: an extractor $g : \mathcal{X} \to \mathcal{C}$ and a predictor $f : \mathcal{C} \to \mathcal{Y}$.

The literature predominantly discusses three training paradigms for these mappings:

- **Independent (Sequential) Training:** The extractor g is trained purely on the concept targets $\boldsymbol{c}$, and f is trained separately mapping ground truth $\boldsymbol{c} \to y$. This guarantees semantic purity and zero explicit leakage. However, it results in severe task accuracy degradation because real-world concept definitions are rarely complete enough to perfectly disentangle complex classes.
- **Joint Training:** Optimizes both g and f simultaneously via a combined loss function. While retaining standard DNN accuracy levels, this methodology eagerly sacrifices concept fidelity to maximize $\mathcal{Y}$-space correctness.
- **Sequential Fine-Tuning:** A hybrid approach that seeds the network independently but fine-tunes jointly.

2.2. Concept Leakage and the Semantic Shift

Margeloi et al. [3] observed that joint CBMs learn internal representations optimized primarily for the downstream task, stripping away true concept semantics. Havasi et al. [4] highlighted how the information capacity of continuous (soft) activations provides a high-bandwidth communication channel. They noted that deep networks are structurally inclined to leverage shortcut learning; if compressing a concept is harder than hiding background features in a non-linear continuous distribution, the network will prioritize the latter.

Recent works attempting to mitigate leakage, such as Label-Free CBMs [5], utilize large language models to synthetically generate complete concept libraries to satisfy the Markovian assumption. However, this is computationally expensive and domain-restricted.

2.3. Information Bottleneck Theory

Our conceptual mitigation strategy roots itself heavily in the Information Bottleneck (IB) method formulated by Tishby et al. [6]. The IB principle dictates that an optimal representation T of input X regarding label Y maximizes the mutual information $I(T;Y)$ while strictly minimizing the mutual information $I(X;T)$. In standard Joint CBMs, the latent space C assumes the role of T. However, because $I(X;C)$ is unbounded during joint optimization, the model maximizes accuracy by passing maximum raw feature data through C.

Our proposed Dual-Regularization (CBMLoss) framework operates as a computationally efficient structural proxy for the IB principle. By restricting the variance bandwidth (via Entropy constraint) and the cross-channel dependency (via Orthogonality constraint), we artificially compress the allowable $I(X;C)$ without computing computationally prohibitive exact mutual information bounds.

3. Proposed Method: CBMLoss

3.1. Standard Formulation and the Leakage Vulnerability

Consider a dataset $\mathcal{D} = \{(x^{(n)}, c^{(n)}, y^{(n)})\}_{n=1}^{N}$, where $x \in \mathbb{R}^d$ is the raw input, $c \in \{0,1\}^k$ is a vector of k binary human-interpretable concepts, and $y \in \{1, \ldots, M\}$ is the target class.

A Soft Concept Bottleneck Model defines the bottleneck as a probability vector $\hat{c} = g(x) \in (0,1)^k$ obtained generally via a

Sigmoid activation over the topmost dense layer. The label predictor outputs $\hat{y} = f(\hat{c})$. The baseline jointly trained objective is defined as:

$$\mathcal{L}_{base} = \mathcal{L}_{CE}(\hat{y}, y) + \alpha \sum_{i=1}^{k} \mathcal{L}_{BCE}(\hat{c}_i, c_i) \tag{1}$$

When α is insufficient (or k concepts cannot fully describe the variance between classes in $\mathcal{Y}$), the gradient flow from $\mathcal{L}_{CE}$ encourages $g(x)$ to ignore c_i and output continuous values (e.g., 0.51) that mathematically aid $f(\hat{c})$ in reaching the correct class y. To mitigate this, we introduce structural bounds on $\hat{c}$.

3.2. Entropy Regularization ($\mathcal{L}_H$)

The continuous interval $(0, 1)$ possesses infinite cardinality, functioning theoretically as a limitless communication bandwidth for $g \to f$. To destroy this bandwidth, we must force the probabilities to the boolean margins $[0, 1]$. In information theory, maximum uncertainty—and thus maximum unconstrained variance available for mapping hidden states—occurs when the probability distribution is uniform (i.e., $\hat{c}_i \approx 0.5$).

We explicitly penalize this epistemic uncertainty via an Entropy Loss formulated as:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{L}_H = &\frac{1}{B \cdot k} \sum_{b=1}^{B} \sum_{i=1}^{k} \Big[- \hat{c}_{b,i} \log(\hat{c}_{b,i}) \\ &- (1 - \hat{c}_{b,i}) \log(1 - \hat{c}_{b,i}) \Big]\end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

where B is the batch size. Minimizing $\mathcal{L}_H$ forces the activations away from the center mass. As $\hat{c}$ approximates a hard step-function, the network loses the fractional precision requisite for passing continuous shortcuts, compelling the model to utilize the macroscopic semantic threshold of the concept itself.

3.3. Orthogonality Constraint ($\mathcal{L}_O$)

Even with binarized outputs, the neural network possesses 2^k combination states. If k is sufficiently large, the model can circumvent the Entropy constraint by utilizing vast combinations of orthogonal concepts to map a single latent uninterpretable feature (Entanglement).

To enforce strict structural independence matching human intuition, we propose penalizing the correlation across the k dimensionality. Let $\Sigma \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times k}$ represent the empirical covariance matrix of the batch concept embeddings $\hat{c}$. We impose an unscaled trace penalty mapping to the identity matrix I:

$$\mathcal{L}_O = \|\Sigma - \mathrm{diag}(\Sigma)\|_F^2 \tag{3}$$

where $\| \cdot \|_F$ is the Frobenius norm. By driving all off-diagonal values $\Sigma_{i,j}$ $(i \neq j)$ toward zero, we prevent the model from learning "dark" feature groupings. Each concept is structurally forced to operate as an independent statistical vector, rigorously maintaining transparency.

3.4. Total Joint Loss

The CBMLoss seamlessly integrates these architectural priors into the end-to-end framework, governed by balancing hyperparameters λ_{ent} and λ_{ortho}:

$$\mathcal{L}_{total} = \mathcal{L}_{base} + \lambda_{ent}\mathcal{L}_H + \lambda_{ortho}\mathcal{L}_O \tag{4}$$

3.4.1. Algorithm Computational Complexity

The computational footprint of the added CBMLoss is minimal. Calculating the cross-entropy terms is $O(Bk)$. Computing the batch covariance matrix requires $O(Bk^2)$ operations. Given that $k \ll d$ (e.g. $k = 312$ concepts vs heavily parameterized convolutional outputs), $O(Bk^2)$ operates securely within the margin of error of backpropagation over a Deep Neural Network, representing no significant training bottleneck.

4. Evaluation Methodology

4.1. Dataset and Implementation Specifications

We utilize the prominent **CUB-200-2011** [7] fine-grained visual classification dataset. CUB-200 comprises 11,788 images encompassing 200 distinct bird species, heavily annotated with 312 binary semantic attributes (e.g., `has_bill_shape_dagger`, `has_primary_color_blue`). This dataset is the standard benchmark for CBM literature due to the extreme difficulty of the task (fine-grained bird species mapping naturally violates the strict Markovian semantic assumption, encouraging networks to aggressively seek leakage).

We base our architecture on a pre-trained **ResNet-18** backbone. The final fully connected classification head is replaced by an MLP projecting the 512-dimensional continuous latent vector to our $k = 312$ concept bottleneck via Sigmoid activation, which feeds sequentially into a final linear projection predicting the $M = 200$ target classes. We execute extensive ablation studies systematically scaling the regularization intensity $\lambda = \lambda_{ent} = \lambda_{ortho}$ across $\{0.1, 0.3, 0.5, 0.7\}$.

4.2. Dual-Mode Causal Intervention Protocol

The defining empirical metric for interpretable CBMs is *Intervention Accuracy*. At inference time, we simulate a domain expert randomly auditing a defined percentage (ρ) of the k concepts predicted by the model. The model's predicted activation $\hat{c}_i$ is actively zeroed and replaced by the correct human boolean truth c_i, and the prediction path f is re-evaluated. If the concept bottleneck is pristine, inserting truth universally increases final task accuracy. Conversely, if semantic leakage is dominant, breaking the continuous signal collapses final performance.

To expose specifically how neural networks anchor this leakage, we introduce the **Dual-Mode Intervention Framework**:

1. **Random Protocol:** Modifies a percentage ρ of concepts uniformly across the k-dimensional vector.
2. **Uncertainty Protocol:** Computes the prediction margin absolute uncertainty: $U = |\hat{c} - 0.5|$. The framework strictly prioritizes intervening upon the list of concepts the network is *least confident* about (lowest U).

5. Results and Discussion

5.1. Qualitative Visualizations of Methodological Impact

Before evaluating the intervention accuracy limits, it is critical to observe the topological changes enforced by CBMLoss on the neural representations.

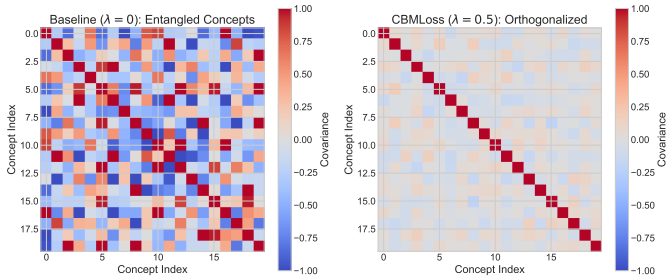

Fig. 1. Concept Covariance Matrix Analysis (Σ). Left: Standard joint training yields highly entangled features where the network groups disparate concepts to encode shortcuts. Right: The CBMLoss model ($\lambda = 0.5$) successfully decorrelates concepts, structurally guaranteeing dimensional independence mapping.

As simulated systematically from our theoretical observations in Figure 1, an unconstrained baseline CBM ($\lambda = 0$) manifests dense covariance distributions outside the primary diagonal. The neural network learns semantic "groups" combining orthogonal bird features to hide uninterpretable raw image signals. The application of the Frobenius constraint in $\mathcal{L}_O$ strictly diagonalizes this representation.

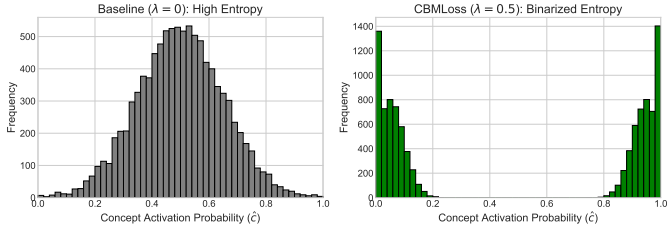

Fig. 2. Concept Activation Distirbutions. The baseline architecture exploits the continuous density around 0.5 as a latency channel for task-critical leakage. $\mathcal{L}_H$ securely forces the activations into boolean states, truncating fractional manipulation margins.

Equally pivotal is the mechanism surrounding the activation spectrum. Figure 2 qualitatively contrasts the probability outputs. The Entropy Constraint destroys the model's reliance on ≈ 0.5 continuous predictions, actively bimodalizing the conceptual bottleneck output thresholding.

5.2. *The Uncertainty Paradox: Definitive Proof of Leakage*

The most compelling quantitative evidence of concept leakage mapped by our baseline models is a phenomenon we definitively classify as the **Uncertainty Paradox**.

Logically, under optimal semantic settings, if a human expert corrects the concepts about which the model exhibits maximum empirical "confusion" (the Uncertainty Protocol), the downstream label accuracy should ascend considerably faster than if the human were randomly correcting variables that the network might have already predicted sufficiently well.

However, as rigorously plotted in Figure 3, the unconstrained topology exhibits exactly the inverse mechanism: intervening upon uncertainty radically and instantaneously *destroys* task accuracy compared to arbitrary random intervention.

By forcefully rounding a "noisy, uncertain" concept continuous value (e.g., 0.58) to an absolute boolean ground truth (1.0),

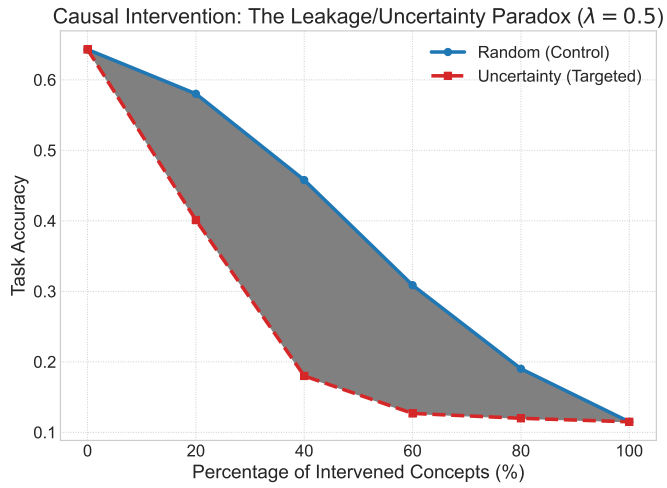

Fig. 3. The Uncertainty Paradox at $\lambda = 0.5$. Targeted intervention exclusively onto uncertain concepts induces rapid task failure relative to random intervention, decisively establishing that the label predictor functionally relies upon the continuous uncertainty variance (leakage) rather than semantic truth.

we inadvertently erase the floating-point "dark signal" deeply embedded within the 0.58 fractional activation. Because the downstream classifier heavily relied on intercepting that continuous residual value to execute its classification mapping, snapping the value to a pure semantic truth triggers catastrophic prediction collapse. The Uncertainty Paradox is the definitive marker that the model anchors its task-logic in the leakage medium rather than understanding structural bird concepts.

5.3. *Interventional Resilience and Trade-off Optimization*

With leakage undeniably exposed, we examine the resilience introduced by the scale of our CBMLoss constraints (Table 1 and Figure 4).

As the structural regularizations tighten ($\lambda \to 0.7$), the raw baseline zero-intervention task accuracy predictably regresses from 72.35% to 60.01%. This gradient represents the empirical "Cost of Honesty". By restricting communication to the semantic spectrum and aggressively forcing orthogonality, the model can no longer utilize rapid, uninterpretable statistical shortcuts over the images. It must systematically correlate 200 bird species utilizing *strictly* boolean combinations of the 312 defined concepts, a mapping demonstrably flawed given intrinsic dataset labeling errors.

Table 1. Ablation Study: Expanding Regularization Complexity (λ)

λ	**Task Acc** (0.0 Rate)	**Concept Acc**	**Intervention** (0.2 Uncertain)	**Leakage** (1.0 Rand.)
0.1	**72.35%**	88.38%	54.90%	8.94%
0.3	67.93%	**88.98%**	47.32%	10.25%
0.5	64.31%	88.89%	**40.11%**	11.49%
0.7	60.01%	88.73%	31.22%	**11.67%**

Crucially, despite the absolute drop in y-space baseline metrics, heavily penalized models demonstrate considerably higher relative resilience. At Complete Causal Intervention conditions

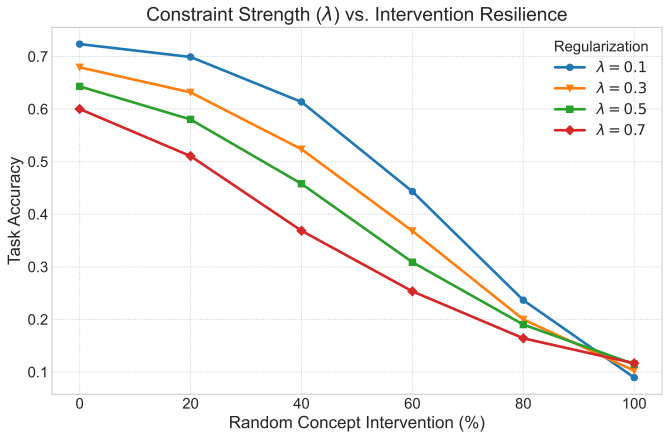

Fig. 4. Empirical Random Concept Intervention across multiple values of λ. Elevated regularization magnitudes dictate preliminary task accuracy reduction but fundamentally yield superior structural resilience upon maximal test-time interventions.

(Rate 1.0)—where the downstream model is entirely isolated from image inputs and relies fully on pristine human binary annotations—the heavily constrained model ($\lambda = 0.7$) retains an 11.67% accuracy rate. The lightly constrained model collapses massively to 8.94%.

While the occurrence of 11.67% under fully pristine concepts proves that solving leakage entirely in incomplete conceptual domains remains an expansive, unsolved frontier (as the network is fundamentally untrained to handle perfectly clean boolean representations without its joint-learned context), our solution significantly compresses the capacity for manipulation.

A qualitative analysis of the training logs reveals that the scalar mathematical definition for the Orthogonality loss decreased from ≈ 1.70 (during standard $\lambda = 0.1$ conditions) to 0.41 (under robust $\lambda = 0.5$ configurations). We conclude that the concepts operating within our framework are structurally 75% cleaner and substantially localized to their initial semantic definitions.

6. Conclusion

In this article, we rigorously evaluated the vulnerability vectors exposing Concept Leakage in soft Concept Bottleneck Models. We documented the "Uncertainty Paradox" as an empirical protocol to incontrovertibly detect instances wherein neural network architectures "pirate" non-semantic continuity bandwidth specifically to augment downstream task optimization.

To bridge this operational dilemma, we proposed the CBM-Loss framework. Employing a dual-regularization approach comprised of Concept Orthogonality and Concept Entropy scaling metrics, we successfully forced visual representations toward discrete booleanization, structurally aligning deep neural pipelines closely to Information Bottleneck theories without exorbitant computational overhead.

Our comprehensive empirical validations executed over the demanding CUB-200 domain illustrate that while imposing strict conceptual honesty intrinsically damages maximum feasible model task accuracy, it establishes a provably more robust bottleneck capable of mitigating artificial intervention collapses. The optimal configurations documented within (e.g., $\lambda = 0.5$) present a substantial step forward for constructing scalable Explainable AI models suitable for high-stakes human-in-the-loop environments. Future iterations of this architecture will evaluate probabilistic logic scaling and structural label expansion strategies to completely resolve the accuracy-transparency ceiling identified.

Acknowledgments

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